

modems can hope to get workable speeds is to connect late at night to an Indian server (such as Kawabonka), or a high-speed server based in Singapore or Hong Kong.

To play Internet games, you need to be online before you fire up your game. Once inside the game of your choice, select the Multiplayer option, then choose TCP/IP and then Internet. Quite a few games also offer an Internet option straight from the Multiplayer menu, so you'll need to select that instead. It'll take a while to search for online servers and connect to them, so be patient.

Dial-up Connection: This method is almost dead now. It's limited to two players and is also the slowest method, and often ends in failure. The procedure involves setting up a dial-up server via the Game Type in the Multiplayer menu of the game. The game in the second machine then dials the server and establishes the connection. The speed is directly dependent on the geographical distance between the players; with increasing distance, the quality of the connection will fall.

The Software Aspect

Once you have the hardware in place, there are quite a few tools available that make life a lot easier as far as setting up and joining game servers is concerned. One such program is GameHost. It specialises in supporting the most popular First Person Shooters, and makes setting up servers for these games a snap. It takes care of all the command-line parameters and complex console commands, presenting them in a graphical format that's easy to understand. The latest version adds support for *Return To Castle Wolfenstein*, in addition to the ones it already supports—*Quake*, *QuakeWorld*, *Quake II*, *Quake III Arena*, *Hexen II*, *Half-Life*, *Sin*, *Starsiege Tribes* and *Unreal Tournament*.

// If we ran it (kawabonka.com) to make money, we would have been forced to shut it down in the first three months itself //

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The server component of GameHost requires at least Windows 2000, due to its improved network handling over previous versions of the OS. The program runs as a service, which means that it starts automatically with Windows, without requiring you to log on to the machine.

On the client side, the most popular software used for connecting to game servers on the Internet is GameSpy Arcade and GameSpy 3D, which between them, support dozens of the most popular games. The tools, offered by the GameSpy Network, take upon themselves the job of scouring the Internet for all servers that are currently hosting the game of your choice, presenting the results by number of players, server ping time (lesser the ping, faster the server), game type, and game map. You can also chat and exchange files with other users, add them to

your buddy list and invite them for game sessions, providing the full functionality of an instant messenger.

Users of the GameSpy software can even perform voice chats with each other, although this requires you to pay a small fee and subscribe to the service. The software can also act as a download manager.

Another tool that multiplayer gamers will find useful in the course of their online

exploits is a Log Analyser. Applications such as Q3Log provide a stylish interface to analyse the logs created by the game server and create an HTML page with player rankings. It supports just *Quake III Arena* and *Return To Castle Wolfenstein*, but is very good at what it does.

Futurama

Practically every game released nowadays features extensive multiplayer support. In developed countries, multiplayer gaming has begun to assume even more importance than the single-player experience. In India though, we still have a long way to go. Until we have broadband, it looks like the only platform avid gamers without high-speed access will have to display their talents would be at competitions hosted at college fests and cybercafes.

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